

Fire in the belly: Ankur

Bhattacharjee, 17, showed the UTT what it was missing out on with his wide array of shots. B.JOTHIRAMALINGAM

couldn't field an equally strong athlete.

Dabang's problems brought to the fore another issue that could be worked on ahead of season six. Diya's injury could have been the result of a tight calendar that cramped a total of 23 ties over 17 days with no breaks in between.

"It is unfortunate what happened to Diya before the match started. She was playing so well. This tournament is too long. Every day it is the same — practice, match, and practice again. Sometimes matches are back-to-back. It is very difficult for players to stay focused. There should be more space where players shouldn't feel physically strained. Maybe the matches can be spread across a month," Vesna opined.

VAR in TT: a possibility?

Additionally, an age-old piece of feedback gained traction again: introducing the option to have a review on close calls when U Mumba's Aruna felt his ball had landed on Sathiyar's side of the table. The umpire, though, went ahead and awarded a point to the Indian paddler.

Eyebrows were raised once again when Cho Seungmin of the Jaipur Patriots was wrongly awarded a point against the PBG Bengaluru Smashers.

However, this is something even the International Table Tennis Federation (ITTF) has found difficult to develop in spite of a few dry runs. While the technology for the same can be difficult to devise, baby steps can be taken with appeals getting checked using the slo-mo action replays on the giant screen.

Shining bright like a diamond

To look at the positives, the league stayed true to its tagline, "*Har Shot Mein Mazaa*" (Every shot is exciting). Seventeen days of end-to-end invigorating table tennis action culminated in the Challengers becoming the first team to retain the UTT title.



The tournament also delivered on the promise of giving a solid platform to youngsters, who are going to take up the mantle of making the country proud in the coming years.

There was fire in the eyes of Ankur Bhattacharjee, 17, who showed the UTT what it was missing out on with his blink-and-you-miss forehand topspin, unorthodox yet dangerously effective sidespin, and an impressive wristy backhand. His aggression, which helps the Kolkata lad get into the mind of his opponent, makes him stand out. Although he was sworn in as a Smasher last season, Ankur had to pull out of the tournament to participate in the South Asian Youth Championship.

Then, of course, there was Diya, who sang the redemption song after an insipid debut in 2023. With her pinpoint placements around the half-long region and quick wit, she won 13 of the last 14 games she played. Of these, she sensationally picked three off Manika, thus exacting revenge for the 2-1 defeat last season. This victory ensured Dabang stayed alive in the race to the semifinal.

Diya, however, has been making waves as a paddler for a while now.

In the last two years, she has won 12 gold, six silver, and eight bronze medals in various national and international tournaments, a testament to her immense potential. She was also named the most promising junior at the Senior Nationals in 2022, the same year she went on to represent India at the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games.

Jeet Chandra's giant-slaying tales have now become routine, hence losing the element of surprise. Coming in as a replacement for the Smashers in 2023, Jeet had then slain India No. 1 Harmeet. He was 20 then. The shining prospect lived up to expectations this time around as well, bedazzling one and all while chop-blocking his way to a 3-0 win over Sharath. Jeet's strong showing caught India coach Massimo Costantini's attention, securing him a reserve spot on the team for the October Asian Championships in Astana.

Justifying the 'Ultimate' in Ultimate Table Tennis isn't much of an uphill climb. With a few tweaks here and some tinkering there, it could, in the foreseeable future, give global leagues like the Chinese Super League, Bundesliga and French Pro A a run for their money.